Ethan Zaruba-Walker

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Dear Trail hiring team,

I am applying for the Forward Deployed Engineer role in Palo Alto. I am based in Emeryville, and two days a week in Palo Alto is a commute I can keep. For three years I have sold and delivered my own client work: first conversation, written spec, build, and production, with the customer still able to check the result.

Trail's posting names the failure I keep seeing. Agents miss the call when they never get the rules, exceptions, and judgment a team has built up over years. A rule on Trail cites the source it came from, and a person approves it before an agent can use it. I would run discovery, write the workflow and the success criterion, build the agentic workflow in Python, and bring the pattern back to Product, Engineering, and Solutions.

What I would do in the seat:

- **Requirements, then the build:** I would write the PRD the build is held to, with the workflow, the success criterion, and milestone acceptance. A content-scoring evaluation shipped only after it hit 95% agreement with human reviewers.
- **Onboarding:** I surface the constraint in the first conversations, then build it in Python. On an IT MSP's pre-sales risk assessments, I automated the manual step and trained the team to extend the workflow. Processing time fell 98%.
- **Multi-project delivery:** I source, scope, and deliver concurrent engagements, up to $18K. Python is the language I reach for. JavaScript, TypeScript, and MCP servers are in production.

I have not held the Forward Deployed Engineer title. The work has been the same motion under Founder and AI Solutions Consultant, after more than two years as a software engineer at IBM. Python, JavaScript, and a written success criterion are what I would bring to the first customer onboarding.

Thank you for your time and consideration. I would welcome the chance to talk about which customer process you want in production first.

Sincerely,

Ethan Zaruba-Walker